

NVIDIA CERTIFIED PROFESSIONAL GEN AI LLMs — PART 2

PROMPT ENGINEERING & LLM ADAPTATION

Complete God-Tier Preparation Guide

Covers: NeMo Stack | Guardrails | NIM | vLLM | TensorRT-LLM | Prompt Learning | CoT | Few-Shot |
Constrained Decoding | Domain Adaptation

2026 Edition | NCP-GENL Exam Preparation

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SECTION 1: PROMPT ENGINEERING FOUNDATIONS

1.1 What is Prompt Engineering?

Prompt engineering is the disciplined practice of designing, optimizing, and structuring input prompts to steer Large Language Models (LLMs) toward producing desired outputs without modifying the underlying model weights. It sits at the intersection of linguistics, cognitive science, and systems engineering. In the NVIDIA ecosystem, prompt engineering is not merely about crafting text strings—it is about building robust, scalable, and observable interaction pipelines that integrate with NeMo Guardrails, NVIDIA Inference Microservices (NIM), and TensorRT-LLM for production deployment.

The core insight of prompt engineering is that LLMs are conditional probability distributions over token sequences: $P(y|x, \theta)$. The prompt x conditions the model to sample from a specific region of the output distribution. Effective prompt engineering maximizes $P(\text{desired_output} \mid \text{prompt}, \theta)$ while minimizing entropy in the response distribution. This requires understanding tokenization dynamics, attention mechanisms, and the inductive biases of decoder-only transformer architectures.

Key Dimensions:

- 1. Instruction Design:** Crafting explicit, unambiguous instructions that align with the model's pre-training objective (next-token prediction). The instruction should minimize ambiguity and leverage the model's learned associations from pre-training and instruction-tuning phases.
- 2. Context Window Management:** Strategically placing critical information within the prompt to exploit positional bias in attention mechanisms. Research shows that information at the beginning and end of long contexts is better retained than information in the middle (the "lost in the middle" phenomenon).
- 3. Output Format Specification:** Using delimiters, schemas, and structured templates to constrain the output space. Critical for downstream parsing, validation, and integration with business logic.
- 4. Meta-Cognitive Prompting:** Prompting the model to reflect on its own reasoning process, verify intermediate steps, and self-correct before producing the final output. Foundation of Chain-of-Thought (CoT) and ReAct patterns.

NVIDIA-Specific Context:

In the NVIDIA stack, prompt engineering is operationalized through NeMo Guardrails' **prompts.yml** configuration files, NeMo Studio's playground interface for rapid iteration, and NIM's optimized inference endpoints that support dynamic prompt templating with Jinja2. The NVIDIA approach emphasizes **task-oriented prompting**—each LLM call performs a specific, verifiable task with defined inputs, outputs, and guardrails.

QUICK REVISION: Prompt Engineering Core

- LLMs are $P(y|x, \theta)$ — prompts condition the output distribution
- Triad: Instruction design + context placement + format specification
- NVIDIA: task-oriented prompting via prompts.yml / Jinja2 templates
- NeMo Guardrails: each LLM call = one specific task with validation
- Positional bias: start/end of context > middle (lost in the middle)
- Meta-cognitive prompting = CoT foundation (model reflects on reasoning)

1.2 Chain-of-Thought (CoT) Prompting

Chain-of-Thought prompting, introduced by Wei et al. (2022), elicits intermediate reasoning steps from LLMs before generating the final answer. The fundamental insight is that decoder-based LLMs, trained on next-token prediction, are naturally capable of generating coherent sequences of reasoning tokens if explicitly prompted to do so. CoT transforms single-step reasoning into multi-step generative process, dramatically improving performance on arithmetic, commonsense, and symbolic reasoning tasks.

Mechanism:

CoT expands the latent reasoning trajectory: instead of directly sampling $P(\text{answer}|\text{question})$, the model samples $P(\text{reasoning_steps} | \text{question}) \rightarrow P(\text{answer} | \text{question}, \text{reasoning_steps})$. This decomposition reduces per-step complexity and allows the model to allocate more compute (generated tokens) to difficult sub-problems. The reasoning chain acts as implicit test-time compute scaling—more reasoning tokens generally correlate with higher accuracy on complex tasks.

Types of CoT:

- 1. Zero-Shot CoT:** Append "Let's think step by step" or similar meta-instructions. No examples needed. Works well for models with strong instruction-following (GPT-4, Llama 3, Nemotron).
- 2. Few-Shot CoT:** Provide 2-8 exemplars showing question, step-by-step reasoning, and final answer. Most reliable for specialized domains.
- 3. Self-Consistency CoT:** Generate multiple reasoning chains with temperature > 0, aggregate via majority voting. Correct paths converge; incorrect paths diverge.
- 4. Tree-of-Thoughts (ToT):** Generalize CoT into search tree where each node is a reasoning state. Enables deliberate problem-solving with backtracking for complex planning tasks.
- 5. ReAct (Reasoning + Acting):** Interleave reasoning steps with tool use actions. Model reasons about needed information, calls external APIs, observes results, continues reasoning. Foundation of agentic LLM systems in NVIDIA ecosystem.

NVIDIA NeMo Implementation:

NVIDIA NeMo supports CoT through **NeMo-Aligner** toolkit, enabling supervised fine-tuning (SFT) on CoT datasets and Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback (RLHF) to optimize reasoning quality. The **Nemotron** family (Nemotron-4, Nemotron-4 340B) are specifically trained with reasoning capabilities and support CoT out-of-the-box. In NeMo Guardrails, CoT is implemented by defining multi-turn flows where each turn elicits a reasoning step, with validation rails checking intermediate outputs for logical consistency.

CoT Prompt Template:

```
Q: A store has 45 apples. They sell 12 in the morning and 8 in the afternoon. How many remain?  
A: Let's solve this step by step.  
Step 1: Start with 45 apples.  
Step 2: Subtract morning sales: 45 - 12 = 33 apples.  
Step 3: Subtract afternoon sales: 33 - 8 = 25 apples.  
Therefore, 25 apples remain.
```

```
Q: [New Question]  
A: Let's solve this step by step.
```

QUICK REVISION: Chain-of-Thought

- CoT = intermediate reasoning steps before final answer
- Zero-Shot CoT: "Let's think step by step" — no examples
- Few-Shot CoT: 2-8 exemplars with reasoning + answer pattern
- Self-Consistency: multiple chains + majority voting
- Tree-of-Thoughts: search tree with backtracking
- ReAct: reasoning interleaved with tool calls (agentic)
- NeMo-Aligner: SFT + RLHF for reasoning optimization
- Nemotron models: native CoT support

1.3 Zero-Shot, One-Shot, and Few-Shot Learning

In-context learning (ICL) is the emergent ability of LLMs to learn new tasks from examples embedded directly in the prompt, without gradient updates to model parameters. First observed in GPT-3, this capability arises from diverse task format exposure during pre-training. The shot count defines the approach: zero-shot (no examples), one-shot (one example), few-shot (2-10+ examples).

Zero-Shot Learning:

Relies entirely on pre-existing knowledge and instruction-following. The prompt contains only task description and input. Most efficient (lowest latency, lowest cost) but requires strong generalization. Works best for tasks well-represented in pre-training corpus or aligned with instruction-tuning objectives. In NVIDIA stack, zero-shot is default for NIM endpoints when no examples are provided in system prompt.

One-Shot Learning:

Provides single exemplar demonstrating desired input-output mapping. Surprisingly effective because model infers task structure, output format, and stylistic preferences from one well-chosen example. Quality is paramount—poor examples degrade performance more than no examples. Ideal for format-sensitive tasks (JSON output, specific tone, structured extraction).

Few-Shot Learning:

Provides 2-10 examples (optimal number depends on context length and task complexity). Examples should be diverse, covering edge cases and different input patterns. Diminishing returns beyond 8-10 examples; excessive examples cause overfitting to specific patterns. In NeMo Studio, few-shot examples managed through "Learning Examples" interface for dynamic testing.

Example Selection Strategies:

- 1. Random Selection:** Simple baseline for homogeneous tasks.
- 2. Semantic Similarity:** Select examples most similar to test input using embeddings (NVIDIA NV-Embed models).
- 3. Diversity Sampling:** Use clustering or maximal marginal relevance to cover different input space regions.
- 4. Hard Negative Mining:** Include examples where model previously failed.
- 5. Curriculum Ordering:** Order simple to complex to guide attention.

QUICK REVISION: Shot-Based Learning

- **Zero-Shot:** task description only — fastest, needs strong base model
- **One-Shot:** single exemplar — great for format/tone specification
- **Few-Shot:** 2-10 examples — optimal for complex tasks
- **Selection:** random, semantic similarity, diversity, hard negatives, curriculum
- **NeMo Studio:** "Learning Examples" UI for dynamic management
- **Guardrails:** few-shot via Jinja2 templates in prompts.yml

1.4 Prompt Templates and Structured Prompting

Prompt templates are reusable, parameterized structures that separate the prompt's static framework from dynamic content. In production systems, templates are essential for maintainability, consistency, and A/B testing. NVIDIA's stack uses Jinja2 templating extensively in NeMo Guardrails and NIM proxy configurations.

Template Components:

- 1. System Prompt:** Defines model persona, constraints, and high-level behavior. Applied at the conversation level. In NeMo Guardrails, configured via **config.yml** under the **models** section with **system_prompt** attribute.
- 2. User Prompt:** The actual task input, often wrapped in delimiters (###, , etc.) to separate from instructions.
- 3. Few-Shot Examples:** Dynamically injected based on retrieval or predefined sets.
- 4. Output Schema:** JSON Schema, XML, or natural language description of expected output structure.
- 5. Constraints:** Length limits, forbidden topics, required citations, tone specifications.

Jinja2 in NeMo Guardrails:

NeMo Guardrails uses Jinja2 for all prompt templating. Variables are injected via **{{ variable_name }}** syntax. The framework provides built-in filters (`first_turns`, `colang`, etc.) and supports custom context variables registered via **LLMRails.register_prompt_context()**. This enables dynamic prompt construction based on conversation state, user profile, or external data sources.

Template Example (prompts.yml):

```
prompts:
- task: generate_user_intent
  content: |
    Below is a conversation between a user and a bot.
    {{ history | colang }}
    User message: "{{ user_input }}"
    What is the user's intent? (respond with ONE word)
    Intent:

- task: self_check_input
  messages:
  - type: system
    content: "You are a safety evaluator."
  - type: user
    content: "Evaluate: {{ user_input }}"
  output_parser: user_intent
```

Structured Output Formats:

JSON Mode: Force model to output valid JSON by specifying schema in prompt and using constrained decoding. NVIDIA NIM supports JSON mode via the **response_format** parameter.

XML Mode: Useful for hierarchical data with nested elements. Better for models with strong XML exposure in training.

Markdown: Good for human-readable structured output with headers, lists, and tables.

Custom Delimiters: Use unique tokens (e.g., `###RESPONSE###`) to make parsing deterministic.

QUICK REVISION: Prompt Templates

- Templates separate static framework from dynamic content
- Components: System prompt + User prompt + Examples + Schema + Constraints
- NeMo Guardrails: Jinja2 templating with `{{ vars }}` and built-in filters
- Register custom context: `LLMRails.register_prompt_context()`
- Output formats: JSON (NIM `response_format`), XML, Markdown, custom delimiters
- System prompt defines persona; user prompt contains actual task

SECTION 2: DOMAIN ADAPTATION & SPECIALIZATION

2.1 Domain Adaptation Strategies

Domain adaptation is the process of adapting a general-purpose LLM to perform effectively on data distributions, vocabularies, and task structures specific to a target domain (e.g., healthcare, finance, legal, semiconductor design). The core challenge is that pre-trained models capture general linguistic patterns but lack domain-specific knowledge, terminology, and reasoning patterns.

Adaptation Spectrum:

1. Prompt Engineering (No Training): Zero-cost adaptation using domain-specific prompts, few-shot examples, and RAG. Best when domain gap is small or when latency/cost constraints prohibit training. Limited by context window and model's base knowledge.

2. Parameter-Efficient Fine-Tuning (PEFT): Adapt only a small subset of parameters (adapters, LoRA, prefix tuning, p-tuning) while freezing the base model. Reduces compute and memory by 100x+ compared to full fine-tuning. NVIDIA NeMo supports LoRA, Adapters, and IA3 via the **peft** integration.

3. Full Fine-Tuning: Update all model parameters on domain-specific corpus. Highest capacity but requires significant compute (multiple A100/H100 GPUs), large curated datasets, and risks catastrophic forgetting of general capabilities. NeMo's **Megatron-LM** framework enables efficient full fine-tuning with tensor parallelism and pipeline parallelism.

4. Continual Pre-training: Further pre-train the base model on domain-specific unlabeled text before task-specific fine-tuning. Best for domains with highly specialized vocabulary (e.g., genomics, chip design) where token embeddings need adaptation.

5. RAG + Fine-Tuning Hybrid: Combine retrieval-augmented generation with light fine-tuning. The model learns to better use retrieved context while the retriever (e.g., NVIDIA's NV-Embed) is optimized for domain-specific embeddings.

Domain-Specific Prompt Engineering:

Before committing to fine-tuning, exhaust prompt engineering options:

- **Domain Terminology Injection:** Include key terms and definitions in the system prompt.
- **Specialized Few-Shot:** Curate examples from the target domain showing desired reasoning patterns.
- **Chain-of-Thought with Domain Logic:** Design CoT prompts that follow domain-specific decision trees.
- **Output Constraints:** Enforce domain-compliant output formats (e.g., medical codes, legal citations).
- **Guardrails:** Use NeMo Guardrails to validate outputs against domain ontologies and compliance rules.

QUICK REVISION: Domain Adaptation

- **Spectrum:** Prompt Eng → PEFT → Full FT → Continual Pre-training → RAG+FT Hybrid
- **PEFT:** LoRA, Adapters, IA3 — 100x+ parameter reduction
- **NeMo:** Megatron-LM for full FT, peft integration for PEFT
- **Continual pre-training:** for specialized vocabularies (genomics, chip design)
- **Always exhaust prompt engineering before fine-tuning**
- **Domain-specific CoT:** follow domain decision trees in reasoning

2.2 Prompt Learning (P-Tuning & Prefix Tuning)

Prompt learning is a parameter-efficient fine-tuning paradigm where soft prompts (continuous vectors) are prepended to the input embeddings, while the base model remains frozen. Unlike discrete prompt engineering (crafting text strings), prompt learning optimizes the prompt embeddings via backpropagation. This bridges the gap between prompt engineering and full fine-tuning, offering task-specific adaptation with minimal parameter overhead.

Prefix Tuning (Li & Liang, 2021):

Prefix tuning prepends trainable continuous vectors to the keys and values of each transformer layer's attention mechanism. These prefix vectors act as virtual tokens that condition the model's behavior. Only the prefix parameters are updated (0.1% of total parameters), while the base model is frozen. The prefix length (typically 10-100 tokens per layer) is a hyperparameter that trades off capacity and compute.

P-Tuning v2 (Liu et al., 2022):

P-Tuning v2 generalizes prefix tuning by applying continuous prompts to deeper layers (not just input layer), improving performance on hard NLU tasks. It uses a prompt encoder (typically a small LSTM or MLP) to generate prompt embeddings that are then prepended to each layer. P-Tuning v2 is particularly effective for small/medium models and tasks requiring fine-grained understanding.

NVIDIA NeMo Implementation:

NeMo supports prompt learning through the **PromptLearningConfig** in `nemo.collections.nlp.modules.common.prompt_learning`. The configuration specifies:

- **prompt_tuning**: Boolean flag to enable prompt tuning mode.
- **virtual_tokens**: Number of virtual tokens to prepend (e.g., 10-100).
- **prompt_encoder**: Type of encoder (lstm, mlp, or none for direct optimization).
- **task_templates**: Template strings with `<|VIRTUAL_PROMPT_#|>` placeholders.
- **new_tasks**: List of task names to create prompts for.
- **existing_tasks**: Tasks with pre-trained prompts to load.

NeMo Prompt Learning Config:

```
model:
  prompt_tuning: true
  prompt_tuning_new_tasks: ['sentiment_analysis', 'ner']
  prompt_tuning_task_templates:
    - taskname: sentiment_analysis
      prompt_template: "{v0} {v1} {v2} {sentence} sentiment:"
      total_virtual_tokens: 10
      virtual_token_splits: [3, 3, 4]
      answer_field: label

  prompt_encoder:
    _target_: nemo.collections.nlp.modules.common.prompt_learning.PromptEncoder
    encoder_type: tpmlp
    num_layers: 2
    bottleneck_dim: 128
```

Advantages of Prompt Learning:

- **Parameter Efficiency**: 0.01-0.1% of base model parameters need training.
- **No Catastrophic Forgetting**: Base model frozen, general capabilities preserved.
- **Task Composability**: Multiple task-specific prompts can be swapped at inference.

- **Storage Efficiency:** Only store small prompt checkpoints per task, not full model copies.
- **Fast Training:** Converges in minutes to hours vs. days for full fine-tuning.

QUICK REVISION: Prompt Learning

- Prompt learning = optimize soft prompt embeddings, freeze base model
- Prefix Tuning: trainable vectors prepended to K,V of each attention layer
- P-Tuning v2: continuous prompts at deeper layers, prompt encoder (LSTM/MLP)
- NeMo: PromptLearningConfig with virtual_tokens, task_templates, prompt_encoder
- Advantages: parameter efficient, no forgetting, task composable, fast training
- Virtual tokens: 10-100 typical; trade-off between capacity and compute

SECTION 3: NVIDIA NeMo STACK DEEP DIVE

3.1 NeMo Framework Architecture

NVIDIA NeMo is an end-to-end framework for building, customizing, and deploying generative AI models. It provides a unified interface across the entire LLM lifecycle: data curation, pre-training, fine-tuning, alignment, guardrailing, and deployment. NeMo is built on PyTorch and leverages NVIDIA's GPU-optimized libraries (cuDNN, cuBLAS, NCCL) for maximum performance.

NeMo Core Components:

- 1. NeMo Core (nemo.core):** Base classes for models, datasets, and optimizers. Implements the **NeuralModule** abstraction where each component is a self-describing unit with typed inputs/outputs. Enables modular composition of complex pipelines.
- 2. NeMo Collections (nemo.collections):** Domain-specific modules organized into collections:
 - **nlp:** NLP models (BERT, GPT, T5, Megatron-LM, Nemotron)
 - **asr:** Automatic Speech Recognition (Conformer, Citrinet)
 - **tts:** Text-to-Speech (FastPitch, RadTTS)
 - **multimodal:** Vision-language models (NeVA, Stable Diffusion)
- 3. NeMo-Aligner:** Toolkit for model alignment including SFT, RLHF (PPO, DPO), SteerLM, and SPIN. Critical for creating instruction-following and reasoning-capable models.
- 4. NeMo Guardrails:** Programmable guardrails for controlling LLM outputs. Defines rails (input, output, dialog, retrieval) as YAML configurations with Colang flow language.
- 5. NeMo Curator:** Data curation pipeline for filtering, deduplication, and quality scoring of pre-training data. Uses GPU-accelerated operations via RAPIDS cuDF and Dask.
- 6. NeMo Deploy:** Deployment tools for exporting models to TensorRT-LLM, Triton Inference Server, and NIM formats.

Megatron-LM Integration:

NeMo integrates **Megatron-LM**, NVIDIA's large-scale transformer training framework. Megatron provides:

- **Tensor Parallelism (TP):** Split individual layers across GPUs. Each GPU computes a portion of attention and MLP. Communication via all-reduce. Typical TP=2,4,8.
- **Pipeline Parallelism (PP):** Split model layers across GPUs. Each GPU holds a stage of the pipeline. Uses bubble scheduling (interleaved 1F1B) to minimize idle time.
- **Sequence Parallelism (SP):** Split sequence dimension across TP group. Reduces activation memory for long sequences.
- **Context Parallelism (CP):** For very long contexts (>32K), split attention computation across sequence dimension with ring attention pattern.
- **Expert Parallelism (EP):** For MoE models, route tokens to different expert GPUs.

NeMo Training Config Structure:

NeMo uses Hydra for configuration management. The main config file (e.g., gpt3_175b.yaml) contains:

- **trainer:** PyTorch Lightning trainer settings (devices, precision, strategy)
- **model:** Model architecture (num_layers, hidden_size, num_attention_heads, ffn_hidden_size)

- **optim**: Optimizer settings (lr, weight_decay, betas, sched)
- **data**: Data module configuration (paths, batch_size, seq_length)
- **exp_manager**: Experiment tracking (checkpointing, logging, WandB/TensorBoard)

QUICK REVISION: NeMo Architecture

- NeMo = end-to-end framework: data curation → pre-train → fine-tune → align → guardrail → deploy
- Collections: nlp, asr, tts, multimodal
- NeMo-Aligner: SFT, RLHF (PPO, DPO), SteerLM, SPIN
- NeMo Guardrails: YAML + Colang for programmable output control
- Megatron-LM: TP (layer split), PP (stage split), SP (seq split), CP (long context), EP (MoE)
- Config: Hydra-based with trainer, model, optim, data, exp_manager sections

3.2 NeMo Guardrails & Constrained Decoding

NeMo Guardrails is an open-source toolkit for adding programmable guardrails to LLM applications. It enables developers to define rails—rules and flows that control the model's behavior at input validation, output generation, and dialog management stages. Guardrails operates on a "rails" metaphor: the LLM runs on tracks defined by the developer, and any deviation is corrected or blocked.

Guardrails Architecture:

1. Input Rails: Validate and filter user inputs before they reach the LLM. Includes:

- **self_check_input:** Moderation check for toxic, harmful, or off-topic content.
- **jailbreak_detection:** Detect prompt injection and adversarial attacks.
- **topic_control:** Ensure inputs are within allowed topic boundaries.

2. Output Rails: Validate and filter LLM outputs before returning to user. Includes:

- **self_check_output:** Check for hallucinations, toxic content, PII leakage.
- **fact_checking:** Ground outputs in retrieved evidence (RAG verification).
- **output_format:** Enforce JSON, XML, or custom schema compliance.

3. Dialog Rails: Manage conversation flow and state. Includes:

- **user_intent:** Classify user intent to route to appropriate flow.
- **bot_intent:** Define bot's intended action (inform, ask, clarify).
- **flow_control:** Multi-turn conversation management with Colang.

4. Retrieval Rails: Control RAG pipeline behavior. Includes:

- **relevance_check:** Ensure retrieved chunks are relevant to query.
- **chunk_selection:** Select optimal chunks for context window.
- **answer grounding:** Force citations to source documents.

Colang Flow Language:

Colang is a domain-specific language for defining conversational flows in Guardrails. It uses natural-language-like syntax to define bot behaviors, user intents, and flow logic. Colang files (.co) are compiled into executable flows that run within the guardrails engine.

Colang Example:

```
define user ask about product
  "What products do you offer?"
  "Tell me about your services"
  "What can I buy?"

define bot inform about products
  "We offer GPUs, DGX systems, and AI software."

define flow product inquiry
  user ask about product
  bot inform about products
  bot ask follow up

define bot ask follow up
  "would you like details on a specific product?"
```

Config.yml Structure:

```
models:
  - type: main
  engine: openai
  model: gpt-4
  system_prompt: "You are a helpful NVIDIA sales assistant."

rails:
  input:
    flows:
      - self_check_input
      - check_jailbreak
  output:
    flows:
      - self_check_output
      - check_hallucination
  dialog:
    single_call:
      enabled: false
  retrieval:
    flows:
      - check_relevance

prompts:
  - task: self_check_input
    content: |
      Check if user message complies with policy.
      Policy: No harmful content, no PII requests.
      User: "{{ user_input }}"
      Block? (Yes/No):
```

Constrained Decoding:

Constrained decoding restricts the model's output to valid tokens according to a grammar or schema. This is critical for:

- **JSON Output:** Force valid JSON structure (keys, values, arrays, nested objects).
- **SQL Generation:** Restrict to valid SQL syntax for database queries.
- **Code Generation:** Enforce language-specific syntax and API constraints.
- **Structured Extraction:** Extract entities into predefined schemas.

NVIDIA implements constrained decoding via:

- **Outlines library:** Regex-based and CFG-based constraints integrated with vLLM.
- **TensorRT-LLM:** Runtime grammar constraints for optimized inference.
- **XGrammar:** NVIDIA's high-performance structured generation engine (0.5ms overhead).

QUICK REVISION: NeMo Guardrails

- **Guardrails = programmable rules for input/output/dialog/retrieval control**
- **Input rails:** self_check_input, jailbreak_detection, topic_control
- **Output rails:** self_check_output, fact_checking, output_format
- **Dialog rails:** user_intent, bot_intent, flow_control via Colang
- **Colang:** natural-language DSL for conversational flows (.co files)
- **Config.yml:** models, rails, prompts sections
- **Constrained decoding:** Outlines, TensorRT-LLM grammar, XGrammar
- **XGrammar:** 0.5ms overhead structured generation

3.3 NVIDIA Inference Microservices (NIM)

NVIDIA Inference Microservices (NIM) are pre-built, optimized containers for deploying foundation models on NVIDIA GPUs. NIM abstracts away the complexity of model optimization, serving infrastructure, and scaling, allowing developers to deploy state-of-the-art models via standard APIs (OpenAI-compatible) in minutes. NIM is a core component of the NVIDIA AI Enterprise suite and is designed for production-grade reliability.

NIM Architecture:

- 1. Model Optimizer:** Automatically applies TensorRT-LLM optimizations (kernel fusion, quantization, speculative decoding) to the target model. Supports FP16, BF16, INT8, and FP8 precisions.
- 2. Triton Inference Server:** Serves optimized models via HTTP/gRPC APIs. Handles dynamic batching, request scheduling, and multi-model concurrency. Integrates with Kubernetes for auto-scaling.
- 3. NIM Proxy:** API gateway that routes requests to appropriate model instances, handles load balancing, and provides unified authentication/authorization.
- 4. Model Store:** Centralized repository for model artifacts, checkpoints, and optimized engines. Supports versioning and A/B testing.
- 5. Observability Stack:** Integrated Prometheus metrics, Grafana dashboards, and NVIDIA DCGM for GPU monitoring.

NIM Deployment Modes:

- 1. Self-Hosted:** Deploy NIM containers on-premises or in private cloud. Full control over data, security, and compliance. Requires NVIDIA AI Enterprise license.
- 2. NVIDIA AI Foundry:** Managed service where NVIDIA handles infrastructure. Pay-per-use pricing. Best for rapid prototyping and variable workloads.
- 3. Cloud Marketplaces:** Deploy via AWS Marketplace, Azure Marketplace, or Google Cloud Marketplace with pre-integrated billing.

NIM API Features:

- **OpenAI Compatibility:** Drop-in replacement for OpenAI API (/v1/chat/completions, /v1/embeddings).
- **Streaming:** Server-sent events (SSE) for real-time token streaming.
- **Batching:** Dynamic batching with configurable max batch size and timeout.
- **Multi-LoRA:** Serve multiple LoRA adapters on a single base model instance.
- **JSON Mode:** Constrained decoding for guaranteed valid JSON output.
- **Function Calling:** Native support for tool use and function calling patterns.
- **Custom System Prompts:** Per-request system prompt override for multi-tenant scenarios.

NIM Configuration Example:

```
# docker-compose.yml for NIM deployment
services:
  nim-llama3:
    image: nvcr.io/nim/meta/llama-3.1-70b-instruct:latest
    runtime: nvidia
    environment:
      - NGC_API_KEY=${NGC_API_KEY}
```

```
- CUDA_VISIBLE_DEVICES=0,1,2,3
volumes:
- ./models:/opt/nim/.cache
ports:
- "8000:8000"
deploy:
resources:
reservations:
devices:
- driver: nvidia
count: 4
capabilities: [gpu]
```

QUICK REVISION: NIM

- NIM = pre-built optimized containers for foundation model deployment
- Components: Model Optimizer, Triton Server, NIM Proxy, Model Store, Observability
- Deployment: Self-hosted (NVIDIA AI Enterprise), AI Foundry (managed), Cloud Marketplaces
- API: OpenAI-compatible, streaming, dynamic batching, multi-LoRA, JSON mode
- TensorRT-LLM optimizations applied automatically (fusion, quantization, speculative decoding)
- Supports FP16, BF16, INT8, FP8 precision modes

3.4 TensorRT-LLM & vLLM Integration

TensorRT-LLM is NVIDIA's high-performance inference engine for LLMs, built on top of TensorRT. It provides GPU-optimized kernels, advanced memory management, and support for the latest NVIDIA architectures (Hopper, Ada Lovelace, Blackwell). vLLM is an open-source inference engine developed at UC Berkeley, known for its PagedAttention memory management. NVIDIA integrates both into its deployment stack.

TensorRT-LLM Key Features:

- 1. Kernel Fusion:** Fuses multiple operations (layernorm + attention + projection) into single CUDA kernels, reducing memory bandwidth and kernel launch overhead.
- 2. Quantization:** Supports INT8, INT4, FP8, and AWQ/GPTQ weight quantization. Reduces memory footprint by 2-4x with minimal accuracy loss.
- 3. Speculative Decoding:** Uses a small draft model to predict multiple tokens, then verifies them in parallel with the main model. Achieves 1.5-2.5x speedup.
- 4. Inflight Batching:** Dynamically batches requests at the token level (not sequence level), maximizing GPU utilization by keeping the compute units busy.
- 5. PagedAttention (vLLM):** Manages KV cache as fixed-size blocks (like OS virtual memory), eliminating memory fragmentation and enabling batch sizes 2-4x larger than naive implementations.
- 6. Multi-GPU Support:** Tensor parallelism, pipeline parallelism, and expert parallelism for serving models that exceed single-GPU memory.

vLLM PagedAttention Mechanism:

Traditional KV cache allocation reserves contiguous memory for the full sequence length, causing massive fragmentation as sequences grow at different rates. vLLM's PagedAttention divides the KV cache into fixed-size blocks (e.g., 16 tokens). Blocks are allocated on-demand and mapped via a block table (like virtual-to-physical memory mapping). This enables:

- **Memory Efficiency:** Near-zero fragmentation, 2-4x more sequences per GPU.
- **Memory Sharing:** Copy-on-write sharing of blocks between parallel decoding branches (beam search, speculative decoding).
- **Dynamic Scheduling:** Preempt and resume sequences by swapping blocks to CPU memory.

TensorRT-LLM Build Process:

- 1. Checkpoint Conversion:** Convert HuggingFace/PyTorch checkpoint to TensorRT-LLM format.
- 2. Weight Quantization:** Apply INT8/FP8/INT4 quantization with calibration.
- 3. Engine Building:** Compile optimized CUDA engines for target GPU architecture.
- 4. Deployment:** Load engines into Triton Inference Server with TensorRT-LLM backend.
- 5. Runtime Optimization:** Enable inflight batching, speculative decoding, and paged KV cache.

QUICK REVISION: TensorRT-LLM & vLLM

- **TensorRT-LLM:** NVIDIA's optimized inference engine (kernel fusion, quantization, speculative decoding)
- **vLLM:** PagedAttention for efficient KV cache management (block-based, virtual memory-like)
- **PagedAttention benefits:** 2-4x more sequences, copy-on-write sharing, dynamic preempt/resume

- **TensorRT-LLM features:** INT8/FP8/INT4 quantization, inflight batching, multi-GPU (TP/PP/EP)
- **Speculative decoding:** draft model predicts tokens, main model verifies → 1.5-2.5x speedup
- **Build process:** checkpoint conversion → quantization → engine build → Triton deployment

SECTION 4: OUTPUT CONTROL & HALLUCINATION MITIGATION

4.1 Validation Pipelines

Validation pipelines are multi-stage systems that verify LLM outputs against correctness, safety, and format constraints before delivery to users. In production systems, validation is not optional—it is a critical reliability layer that prevents hallucinations, toxic outputs, and compliance violations from reaching end users.

Validation Stages:

- 1. Syntactic Validation:** Check output format compliance (JSON schema, XML structure, regex patterns). Tools: jsonschema, pydantic, NVIDIA's XGrammar for structured generation.
- 2. Semantic Validation:** Verify that output meaning aligns with input intent. Techniques:
 - **Intent Consistency:** Classify output intent and compare with expected intent.
 - **Entailment Checking:** Use NLI models to verify if output is entailed by input + context.
 - **Relevance Scoring:** Compute embedding similarity between query and response.
- 3. Factual Validation:** Ground outputs in evidence. Techniques:
 - **RAG Verification:** Cross-reference claims with retrieved documents.
 - **Knowledge Graph Lookup:** Verify entities and relations against structured knowledge bases.
 - **External API Validation:** Check numerical claims against calculators, databases, or search APIs.
- 4. Safety Validation:** Filter toxic, biased, or policy-violating content. Techniques:
 - **Toxicity Classifiers:** NVIDIA's Aegis model or Perspective API.
 - **PII Detection:** Regex + NER for detecting leaked personal information.
 - **Jailbreak Detection:** Pattern matching + classifier for adversarial inputs.
- 5. Business Logic Validation:** Domain-specific checks (e.g., medical codes valid, legal citations correct, financial calculations accurate).

NeMo Guardrails Validation Integration:

Guardrails implements validation as a pipeline of **flows** defined in config.yml. Each flow is a sequence of actions that can call LLMs, external APIs, or custom Python functions. The output of each flow determines whether the response proceeds to the next stage or is blocked/revised.

Example flow:

1. User sends message → **input validation** (self_check_input)
2. Intent classification → route to appropriate handler
3. LLM generates response → **output validation** (self_check_output)
4. Fact checking against retrieved documents → **retrieval validation**
5. If all checks pass → deliver to user; else → fallback response

QUICK REVISION: Validation Pipelines

- **5 validation stages:** Syntactic → Semantic → Factual → Safety → Business Logic
- **Syntactic:** JSON schema, pydantic, XGrammar
- **Semantic:** intent consistency, entailment checking, relevance scoring

- **Factual:** RAG verification, knowledge graph, external API validation
- **Safety:** Aegis toxicity, PII detection, jailbreak detection
- **Guardrails:** flows = sequences of validation actions in config.yml
- **Failed validation** → fallback response, not delivery to user

4.2 Constrained Decoding Techniques

Constrained decoding modifies the token sampling process to ensure outputs conform to a formal grammar, schema, or set of rules. Unlike post-hoc validation (which rejects invalid outputs), constrained decoding prevents invalid outputs from being generated in the first place, improving both reliability and efficiency.

Approaches:

- 1. Logits Masking:** At each generation step, set logits of invalid tokens to -infinity before softmax. Simple but requires pre-computing valid token sets at each position.
- 2. Finite State Machines (FSM):** Represent the output grammar as a state machine. At each step, the current state determines valid next tokens. Used by Outlines library and vLLM integration.
- 3. Context-Free Grammars (CFG):** More expressive than FSM, supports nested structures (JSON, SQL, code). XGrammar and TensorRT-LLM use CFG-based constrained decoding.
- 4. Token Healing:** When a constraint boundary is reached (e.g., end of JSON object), automatically adjust tokenization to ensure clean boundary transitions without partial tokens.
- 5. Guided Decoding:** Use a guide model or classifier to steer the main model toward valid outputs. Used in speculative decoding with constrained draft models.

XGrammar (NVIDIA's Structured Generation):

XGrammar is NVIDIA's high-performance engine for structured generation from LLMs. Key features:

- **0.5ms overhead:** Near-zero latency penalty for grammar constraints.
- **EBNF Grammar Support:** Expressive grammar definition using Extended Backus-Naur Form.
- **JSON Schema Compilation:** Automatically convert JSON schemas to efficient grammar representations.
- **Token-Level Optimization:** Pre-compute valid token masks for each grammar state, enabling fast logits masking.
- **Integration:** Works with vLLM, TensorRT-LLM, and NIM endpoints.

JSON Mode Implementation:

```
# Using NIM API with JSON mode
import openai
client = openai.OpenAI(base_url="http://localhost:8000/v1", api_key="nim-api-key")
response = client.chat.completions.create(
    model="meta/llama-3.1-70b-instruct",
    messages=[{"role": "user", "content": "Extract name and age"}],
    response_format={"type": "json_object"},
    extra_body={"guided_json": {
        "type": "object",
        "properties": {
            "name": {"type": "string"},
            "age": {"type": "integer"}
        },
        "required": ["name", "age"]
    }}
)
```

QUICK REVISION: Constrained Decoding

- Constrained decoding = prevent invalid outputs at generation time (not post-hoc)
- Approaches: Logits masking, FSM, CFG, Token healing, Guided decoding
- XGrammar: NVIDIA's structured generation engine, 0.5ms overhead, EBNF support
- JSON Schema → grammar compilation for automatic constraint generation
- NIM API: `response_format="json_object"` + `guided_json` parameter
- TensorRT-LLM and vLLM both support XGrammar integration

4.3 Self-Consistency & Fact-Checking

Self-consistency and fact-checking are post-generation techniques to improve output reliability. They exploit the stochastic nature of LLM sampling to either aggregate multiple outputs or verify claims against external evidence.

Self-Consistency:

Generate N independent responses (with temperature > 0), then aggregate:

- **Majority Voting:** For categorical answers, select the most frequent response.
- **Weighted Voting:** Weight responses by confidence scores or generation probability.
- **Consistency Score:** Measure pairwise similarity between responses; low consistency indicates high uncertainty.
- **Best-of-N:** Use a reward model or verifier to select the highest-quality response from N candidates.

NVIDIA's Nemotron-4 340B includes a **Reward Model** specifically trained for best-of-N selection and RLHF optimization.

Fact-Checking Pipeline:

1. **Claim Extraction:** Parse LLM output into atomic factual claims using NER and dependency parsing.
2. **Evidence Retrieval:** Search knowledge bases, documents, or web for supporting/contradicting evidence.
3. **NLI Verification:** Use Natural Language Inference model to classify claim-evidence relationship:
 - **Entailment:** Evidence supports claim.
 - **Contradiction:** Evidence refutes claim.
 - **Neutral:** Evidence is irrelevant.
4. **Confidence Scoring:** Aggregate NLI scores across multiple evidence sources.
5. **Action:** If claim is contradicted → flag for review, trigger fallback, or request clarification.

In NeMo Guardrails, fact-checking is implemented via the **self_check_facts** task in prompts.yml, which compares the bot response against retrieved evidence.

QUICK REVISION: Self-Consistency & Fact-Checking

- **Self-Consistency:** generate N responses, aggregate via majority/weighted voting or best-of-N
- **Best-of-N:** Nemotron-4 340B Reward Model selects highest quality response
- **Fact-Checking:** Claim extraction → Evidence retrieval → NLI verification → Confidence scoring
- **NLI labels:** Entailment (supports), Contradiction (refutes), Neutral (irrelevant)
- **Guardrails:** self_check_facts task compares response against evidence
- **Low consistency across N samples = high uncertainty → flag for review**

SECTION 5: PRODUCTION PIPELINES & BEST PRACTICES

5.1 End-to-End Deployment Architecture

A production-grade LLM deployment in the NVIDIA ecosystem follows a layered architecture that separates concerns across data ingestion, model serving, guardrailing, and observability. The following architecture represents NVIDIA's recommended pattern for enterprise GenAI applications.

Architecture Layers:

Layer 1: Client Interface

- REST/gRPC API gateway (NIM Proxy, Kong, Envoy)
- Authentication (OAuth2, API keys, mTLS)
- Rate limiting and request validation
- Multi-tenant routing (isolate prompts/context per tenant)

Layer 2: Application Logic

- NeMo Guardrails engine (input/output/dialog/retrieval rails)
- RAG pipeline (retriever + reranker + context assembler)
- Prompt management service (versioning, A/B testing, dynamic templates)
- Session management (conversation state, context window tracking)

Layer 3: Model Serving

- Triton Inference Server with TensorRT-LLM backend
- vLLM instances for high-throughput scenarios
- NIM containers for pre-optimized foundation models
- Multi-LoRA serving (single base model + task-specific adapters)

Layer 4: Data & Storage

- Vector database (Milvus, pgvector, NVIDIA's vector search)
- Document store (S3, MinIO, NVIDIA AI Store)
- Cache layer (Redis for prompt/response caching)
- Logging store (Elasticsearch, Splunk for audit trails)

Layer 5: Observability

- Prometheus + Grafana for metrics dashboards
- NVIDIA DCGM for GPU monitoring
- Distributed tracing (Jaeger, OpenTelemetry)
- LLM-specific metrics (token latency, TTFT, TBT, hallucination rate)

Request Flow:

1. **Request Ingress:** Client sends prompt → API Gateway authenticates and routes.
2. **Input Validation:** Guardrails input rails check for toxicity, jailbreak, topic compliance.
3. **Context Assembly:** Retrieve relevant documents from vector DB, assemble context window.
4. **Prompt Construction:** Apply template (system prompt + context + user input + few-shot examples).
5. **Model Inference:** Send to Triton/NIM with TensorRT-LLM optimization.
6. **Output Validation:** Guardrails output rails check for hallucinations, format compliance, safety.

7. **Response Delivery:** Stream or return final response to client.

8. **Logging & Feedback:** Log interaction, capture user feedback for RLHF loop.

QUICK REVISION: Production Architecture

- 5 layers: Client Interface → Application Logic → Model Serving → Data & Storage → Observability
- Guardrails at Layer 2: input validation before inference, output validation after
- Triton + TensorRT-LLM at Layer 3 for optimized serving
- Vector DB + document store at Layer 4 for RAG
- Prometheus + DCGM + OpenTelemetry at Layer 5 for monitoring
- Key metrics: TTFT (time to first token), TBT (time between tokens), hallucination rate

5.2 Observability & Monitoring

Observability for LLM systems goes beyond traditional infrastructure monitoring. It requires tracking model behavior, output quality, and business impact in real-time. NVIDIA provides integrated observability through DCGM, Triton metrics, and custom LLM-specific telemetry.

Key Metrics:

Inference Performance:

- **TTFT (Time To First Token):** Latency from request to first generated token. Target: < 100ms for chat.
- **TBT (Time Between Tokens):** Inter-token latency. Target: < 50ms for smooth streaming.
- **Throughput:** Tokens/second across all concurrent requests.
- **Queue Time:** Time spent waiting for GPU availability.

Model Quality:

- **Hallucination Rate:** % of outputs with factual errors (measured via fact-checking pipeline).
- **Toxicity Score:** % of outputs flagged by safety classifiers.
- **Relevance Score:** Embedding similarity between query and response.
- **User Satisfaction:** Explicit feedback (thumbs up/down) or implicit signals (dwell time, follow-up rate).

Resource Utilization:

- **GPU Utilization:** % of GPU compute used (target: > 80%).
- **Memory Usage:** VRAM consumption including KV cache, model weights, activations.
- **Power Consumption:** Watts per request for cost optimization.

NVIDIA DCGM Integration:

NVIDIA Data Center GPU Manager (DCGM) provides GPU health and performance monitoring. Key capabilities:

- **GPU Diagnostics:** Detect hardware errors, thermal throttling, memory ECC errors.
- **Performance Profiling:** Track SM utilization, memory bandwidth, PCIe throughput.
- **Policy Enforcement:** Automatically throttle or migrate workloads on unhealthy GPUs.
- **Integration:** Exposes metrics via Prometheus exporter for Grafana dashboards.

QUICK REVISION: Observability

- **TTFT:** time to first token (< 100ms target)
- **TBT:** time between tokens (< 50ms target)
- **Quality metrics:** hallucination rate, toxicity score, relevance score, user satisfaction
- **Resource:** GPU utilization (> 80% target), VRAM usage, power consumption
- **DCGM:** GPU diagnostics, performance profiling, policy enforcement, Prometheus export
- **Full observability = infrastructure + model quality + business impact metrics**

SECTION 6: QUICK REVISION MASTER SHEET

Complete At-a-Glance Reference for Exam Day

This section consolidates all critical concepts, configurations, and decision frameworks into rapid-review format. Use this as your last-minute study guide before entering the exam.

6.1 Prompt Engineering Decision Matrix

Scenario New task, no training data
Technique Zero-Shot + System Prompt
NVIDIA Tool NeMo Studio, NIM
Format-sensitive output needed One-Shot + JSON Mode
NIM response_format XGrammar
Complex reasoning required Few-Shot
CoT NeMo-Aligner
SFT Domain-specific terminology
RAG + Domain Prompts
NeMo Curator, NV-Embed
Safety-critical application Guardrails + Constrained Decoding
NeMo Guardrails, TensorRT-LLM
Multiple tasks, same model Prompt Learning (P-Tuning)
NeMo PromptLearningConfig High throughput, low latency
TensorRT-LLM + Inflight Batching
NIM, Triton Inference Server
Long context windows Context Parallelism + PagedAttention
TensorRT-LLM, vLLM

6.2 NeMo Configuration File Reference

config.yml (Guardrails):

- **models:** Define LLM engine, model name, system prompt, parameters
- **rails:** Configure input/output/dialog/retrieval flows
- **prompts:** Task-specific prompt templates with Jinja2 variables
- **instructions:** High-level behavior instructions for the bot
- **flows:** Colang conversation flows (.co files referenced)

prompts.yml:

- **task:** Built-in (self_check_input, generate_user_intent) or custom
- **content:** Prompt text with {{ variable }} substitution
- **messages:** Chat format with type (system/user/assistant)
- **models:** Model-specific prompt overrides
- **mode:** Standard/compact for latency optimization
- **output_parser:** Parse LLM output into structured format
- **max_length:** Max tokens for this specific task

Hydra Config (Training):

- **trainer:** devices, precision (bf16/mixed), strategy (ddp/fsdp)
- **model:** num_layers, hidden_size, num_attention_heads, ffn_hidden_size
- **optim:** lr, weight_decay, betas, scheduler (cosine/warmup)
- **data:** paths, batch_size, seq_length, num_workers
- **exp_manager:** checkpointing, logging, WandB/TensorBoard

6.3 Key Hyperparameters & Their Effects

Parameter	Range	Effect
Temperature	0.0 - 2.00	= deterministic, >1 = creative/random
Top-p (nucleus)	0.0 - 1.0	1.0 = full vocab, 0.1 = only high-prob tokens
Top-k1	-	vocab_sizeLimit to k highest probability tokens
Max tokens	1 - 4096+	Hard limit on response length
Repetition penalty	1.0 - 2.0	>1.0 discourages token repetition
Frequency penalty	-2.0 -	

2.0 Penalize tokens based on frequency in text Presence penalty-2.0 - 2.0 Penalize tokens that have appeared at all

6.4 NVIDIA Stack Component Map

Data Layer: NeMo Curator (GPU-accelerated filtering/dedup) + RAPIDS cuDF

Training Layer: NeMo Core + Megatron-LM (TP/PP/SP/CP/EP) + NeMo-Aligner (SFT/RLHF)

Optimization Layer: TensorRT-LLM (kernel fusion, quantization, speculative decoding)

Serving Layer: Triton Inference Server + NIM containers + vLLM (PagedAttention)

Control Layer: NeMo Guardrails (YAML/Colang) + XGrammar (structured generation)

Application Layer: NeMo Studio (playground) + NIM Proxy (API gateway)

Observability Layer: Prometheus + Grafana + DCGM + OpenTelemetry

6.5 Common Failure Modes & Mitigations

Failure Cause	Fix
Hallucinations	Model generates ungrounded claims RAG + fact_checking rails + constrained decoding
Toxic outputs	Unsafe content generation self_check_output + Aegis classifier + input filtering
Format violations	Invalid JSON/XML/schema JSON mode + XGrammar + pydantic validation
High latency	Large model, long sequences TensorRT-LLM + speculative decoding + quantization
Context overflow	Input exceeds context window Chunking + summarization + context parallelism
Catastrophic forgetting	Full FT overwrites general knowledge LoRA/Adapters + replay buffer + PEFT
Jailbreak attacks	Adversarial prompt injection jailbreak_detection rail + input sanitization

6.6 Exam Hot Topics (High Probability)

- 1. NeMo Guardrails Configuration:** Know config.yml structure, flow types, Colang syntax, prompt templates.
- 2. Prompt Learning vs Fine-Tuning:** When to use P-Tuning/Prefix Tuning vs LoRA vs full FT. Parameter counts, pros/cons, use cases.
- 3. Constrained Decoding:** XGrammar, JSON mode, logits masking, FSM vs CFG. Implementation in NIM and TensorRT-LLM.
- 4. RAG Integration:** How Guardrails retrieval rails work, chunking strategies, embedding models (NV-Embed), relevance checking.
- 5. Production Metrics:** TTFT, TBT, throughput, hallucination rate. What they measure and target values.
- 6. Multi-GPU Training:** Tensor parallelism vs pipeline parallelism vs sequence parallelism. When to use each.
- 7. Safety & Compliance:** Input validation, output filtering, PII detection, fact-checking pipelines.
- 8. NIM Deployment:** Docker deployment, API compatibility, multi-LoRA, JSON mode, streaming.
- 9. Chain-of-Thought Patterns:** Zero-shot vs few-shot CoT, self-consistency, Tree-of-Thoughts, ReAct.
- 10. Domain Adaptation Spectrum:** Prompt engineering → PEFT → full FT → continual pre-training. Decision criteria.

SECTION 7: EXAM STRATEGY & KEY TAKEAWAYS

7.1 Question-Type Strategy

Scenario-Based Multi-Select (30% of exam):

- Read the scenario carefully — identify the CONSTRAINTS (latency, safety, data availability, budget).
- Eliminate obviously wrong options first (e.g., full fine-tuning when only 10 examples exist).
- Look for NVIDIA-specific answers: Guardrails, NIM, TensorRT-LLM, NeMo-Aligner.
- Trade-off reasoning: If the question mentions "production deployment with low latency," think TensorRT-LLM + NIM.
- If the question mentions "safety-critical healthcare application," think Guardrails + constrained decoding + fact-checking.

Single-Select Conceptual:

- Know the definitions cold: P-Tuning vs Prefix Tuning, TTFT vs TBT, TP vs PP.
- Understand cause-and-effect: "What happens if temperature is 0?" → deterministic output.
- Configuration knowledge: What goes in config.yml vs prompts.yml vs Hydra config.

7.2 Critical Distinctions to Memorize

Prompt Engineering vs Prompt Learning:

- Prompt Engineering = crafting text strings (discrete, no training, manual)
- Prompt Learning = optimizing continuous vectors (soft prompts, backpropagation, automatic)

Zero-Shot CoT vs Few-Shot CoT:

- Zero-Shot CoT = "Let's think step by step" with NO examples
- Few-Shot CoT = includes 2-8 exemplars with reasoning chains

Tensor Parallelism vs Pipeline Parallelism:

- TP = split LAYERS across GPUs (attention/MLP split within layer)
- PP = split MODEL STAGES across GPUs (layer 1-12 on GPU 0, 13-24 on GPU 1)

Self-Check Input vs Self-Check Output:

- Input = validate USER MESSAGE before LLM sees it
- Output = validate LLM RESPONSE before user sees it

NIM vs Triton vs vLLM:

- NIM = pre-built optimized containers (highest abstraction)
- Triton = inference server (middle abstraction, supports multiple backends)
- vLLM = inference engine (lower abstraction, PagedAttention focus)

XGrammar vs Outlines:

- XGrammar = NVIDIA's engine, 0.5ms overhead, EBNF support
- Outlines = open-source, regex/CFG, integrates with vLLM

7.3 Configuration File Quick Reference

When you see a question about:

- **Conversation flows** → Think Colang (.co files) + config.yml dialog section

- **Prompt customization** → Think prompts.yml with Jinja2 templates
- **Model architecture** → Think Hydra config (model: num_layers, hidden_size, etc.)
- **Safety checks** → Think rails: input/output flows in config.yml
- **Task-specific adaptation** → Think PromptLearningConfig with virtual_tokens
- **Deployment optimization** → Think TensorRT-LLM engine build + Triton backend
- **API integration** → Think NIM with OpenAI-compatible endpoints

7.4 Final Exam Checklist

- Can I explain $P(y|x, \theta)$ and how prompts condition the distribution?
- Can I write a Colang flow for a 3-turn conversation?
- Can I configure self_check_input and self_check_output in prompts.yml?
- Do I know when to use zero-shot vs few-shot vs prompt learning vs LoRA?
- Can I explain PagedAttention and why it improves throughput?
- Do I know the difference between TP, PP, SP, and CP in Megatron-LM?
- Can I describe the full RAG + Guardrails + NIM deployment pipeline?
- Do I know target values for TTFT (<100ms) and TBT (<50ms)?
- Can I explain constrained decoding with XGrammar?
- Do I understand the NeMo stack hierarchy (Curator → NeMo → TensorRT-LLM → Triton → NIM)?
- Can I identify hallucination mitigation strategies (RAG, fact-checking, self-consistency)?
- Do I know the 5 validation stages (Syntactic → Semantic → Factual → Safety → Business)?

7.5 Key NVIDIA-Specific Answers

When in doubt, these are the "NVIDIA way" answers for common scenarios:

- **Low-latency production serving:** TensorRT-LLM + Triton + NIM
- **Safety and compliance:** NeMo Guardrails with input/output/retrieval rails
- **Domain adaptation with limited data:** P-Tuning or LoRA via NeMo PEFT
- **Structured output (JSON/SQL):** XGrammar or NIM JSON mode
- **Long context windows:** Context Parallelism + PagedAttention (vLLM)
- **Multi-task serving:** Multi-LoRA on single base model via NIM
- **Data curation at scale:** NeMo Curator with RAPIDS GPU acceleration
- **Model alignment (RLHF):** NeMo-Aligner with PPO/DPO/SteerLM
- **Reasoning enhancement:** CoT fine-tuning via NeMo-Aligner SFT on reasoning datasets
- **Hallucination reduction:** RAG + self_check_facts + constrained decoding + self-consistency

— END OF CONCEPT GUIDE —
Proceed to MCQ Practice in Next Prompt